

MYTH-BUSTER

I have back problems, so I can't do yoga.

Research suggests that yoga is safe and effective for relieving chronic back pain. However, you may need to make adjustments to certain asanas or avoid some poses completely if you are managing a specific back condition (see pp.202–205). For many people, for example, touching the floor in Standing Forward Fold is not possible or comfortable, particularly for the lower back (the lumbar spine). However, you can still get the main benefits of the pose by bringing the floor closer to you, for example, by resting your hands on a block or on the base of a chair.

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Q IS THERE AN ALTERNATIVE TO ROLLING UP FROM A STANDING FORWARD FOLD?

The cue of rolling up from a Standing Forward Fold “vertebra by vertebra” is likely to have come from the dance world. Biomechanically and functionally, this transition has more risks than benefits. For many, it feels good and improves coordination. However, rolling up could lead to or exacerbate a herniated disk or a spinal fracture for those with osteoporosis. This transition also doesn't prepare you properly for real-world activities, such as picking things up safely. To avoid potential injury, and to build the muscle memory of

safe movement patterns, try coming out of a Standing Forward Fold in the following way:

- 1 **Create a wider base** of support with your toes turned out slightly. This reduces the pressure on your knees.
- 2 **Bring your hands to** your hips or the front of your thighs.
- 3 **Keeping a neutral spine,** engage your core and push up to standing, as with a hip hinge. This can particularly recruit your transversus abdominis, which may help alleviate lower back pain.



Did you know?

BACK PAIN IS ONE OF THE MOST COMMON **DISABLING AILMENTS** AND IS A LEADING CAUSE OF **LOST PRODUCTIVITY**. RESEARCH SHOWS YOGA NOT ONLY **REDUCES BACK PAIN** BY CLINICALLY SIGNIFICANT LEVELS, BUT ALSO **REDUCES** THE NUMBER OF SICK DAYS TAKEN.